

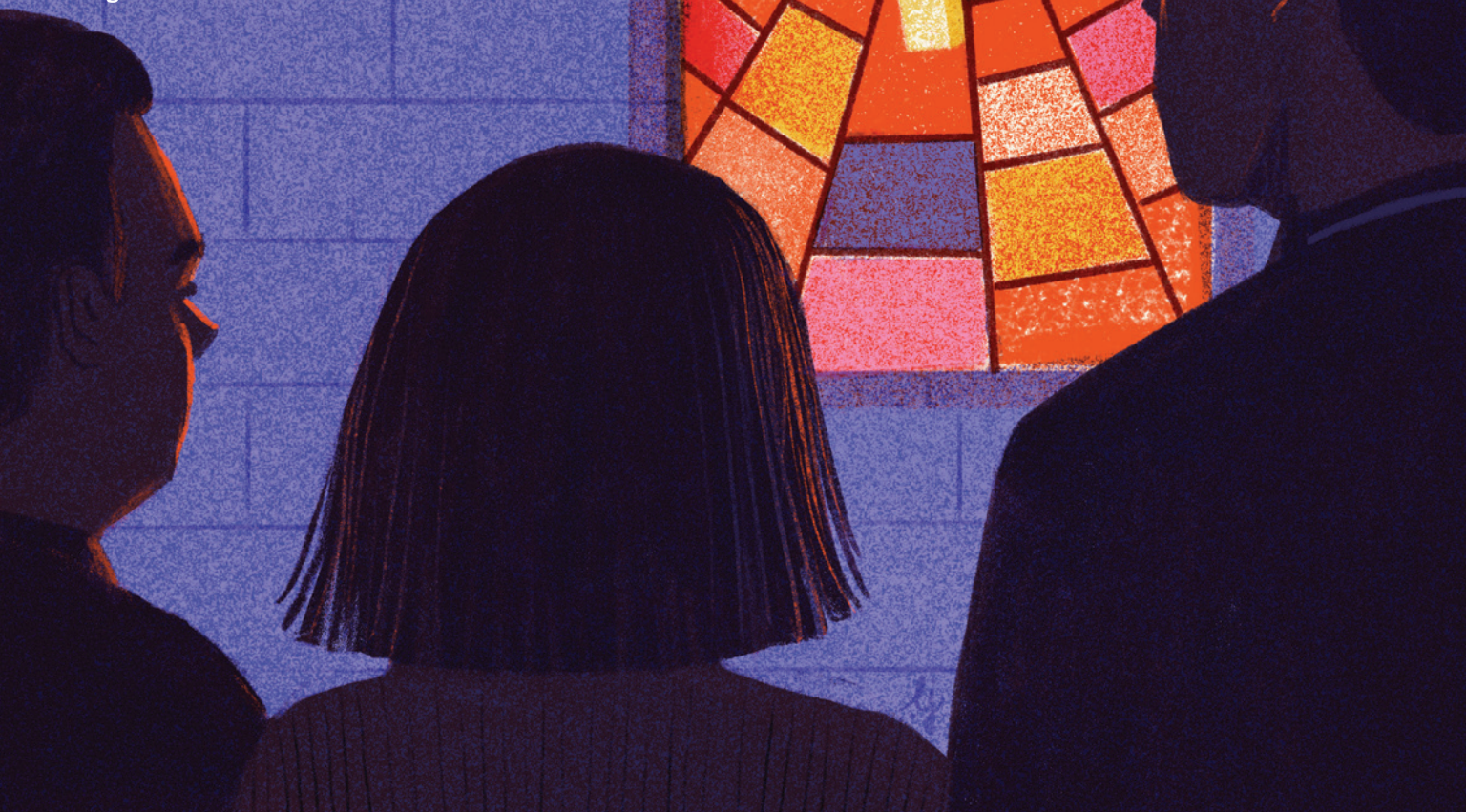


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REVIEW**

May 2026

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Editorial

ONE SINGLE LETTER

Differentiating Belteshazzar from Belshazzar

JUSTIN KIM



In some parts of the world, parents give their children one name but then call them by another. The second name may be diminutive (Elizabeth to Lizzie) or a rhyme (William to Bill) of the first. Some cultures use patronyms or matronyms, referring to children by their parent's name in some way, while teknonymic cultures refer to individuals by their children. Sometimes multiple names denote lineage, honor family members, and other such reasons.

We use names in context. When in communities that know my family, I may be referred to as Scott's son. When around my children's friends, they call me Noah's dad. In English circles I am Justin, while in familiar Korean circles, Jungwon. As a child, any time I heard my surname first followed by my Korean name (Kim Jungwon), I knew I was in trouble, because that is how angry Korean mothers call their children.

In the ancient world, names evoked the power and context of the gods. In the Hebrew culture the roots of the monotheistic name of Yahweh and Elohim are embedded in the *yah* and *el* roots, as in Jeremiah and Nathaniel, respectively. In the book of Daniel we encounter four young men whose names are Daniel, Hananiah, Mishael, and Azariah. By changing their names to Belteshazzar, Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego—all containing the name of a Babylonian god—the Babylonian authorities hoped to reeducate their values, worldviews, and religion.

This name change comes into particular focus in Daniel 5, where the new antagonist's name is Belshazzar. How similar it is to Daniel's Babylonian name, Belteshazzar! The names are the same except for one Hebrew letter, which makes the “te” sound. In Nebuchadnezzar's testimony he uses the Hebrew name “Daniel” twice (Dan. 4:8, 19), preferring the name “Belteshazzar,” which is used six times (verses 8, 9, 18, 19). Inversely, “Belteshazzar” is used only once

in chapter 5, by the queen mother (Dan. 5:12), whereas “Daniel” appears seven times (verses 12, 13, 17, 29). In other words, the author of Daniel seems to have a natural aversion for the Babylonian name and uses it only when absolutely necessary.*

The intentional similarity of the names warrants a comparison of the two characters. Both young men were rebellious: the young Daniel against the gods and system of Babylon, while the young Belshazzar against the God of Israel. Daniel refused to follow the laws of men that conflicted with the laws of heaven, but Belshazzar profaned the holy vessels of God. Both were of royal blood: Belshazzar the grandson of King Nebuchadnezzar and Belteshazzar also of royal descent (cf. Dan. 1:3).

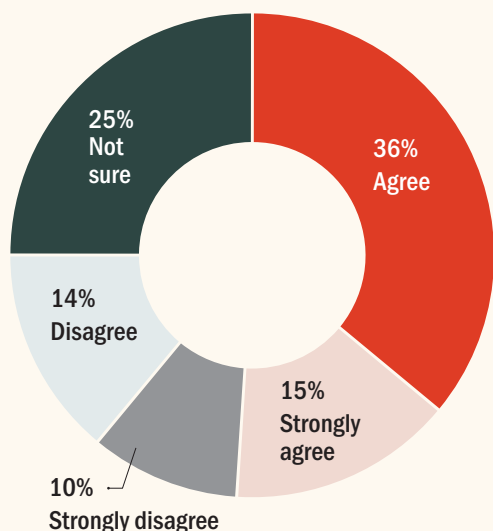
Whereas Daniel refused to drink wine and that which would impair his faculties, Belshazzar embraced debauchery and drunkenness. The former dared not to mix the holy with the unholy, while the latter brought the temple vessels, drank wine from them, and praised his gods.

Last, both knew of the testimony of Nebuchadnezzar. Daniel was involved in the former king's conversion and reminded the grandson of his grandfather's rise, fall, and redemption. Belshazzar “knew all this” (Dan. 5:22) yet still lifted himself up against the God of heaven. One learned from the lessons of the past, while the other eschewed them.

Though similar, the one difference is the “t” sound. Some scholars have intimated this might have been Daniel's way of rebelling against his imposed label. Interestingly the letter *tav* in the paleo-Hebrew script was written as a cross. One small cross differentiated a life of integrity, prophetic providence, righteousness, and salvation. The absence of a small cross marked a life of arrogance, fear, rebellion, and perdition. Are your name, life, and identity differentiated by a single cross? 

* Shea, William H. “Bel(t)shazzar Meets Belshazzar,” *Andrews University Seminary Studies*, Spring 1988, vol. 26, no. 1, p. 73.

DOES YOUR LOCAL CHURCH OFFER TRAINING IN CONFLICT RESOLUTION?



Church members were asked about opportunities in their local congregation to learn how to better solve interpersonal conflict.



N = 146,115
Source: 2022-2023 Global Church Member Survey

Data provided by the General Conference Office of Archives, Statistics, and Research.

“God doesn’t call us to fix everything. He calls us to be faithful with what’s in front of us. To respond to need with justice and mercy. To remember that when we’re kind to the vulnerable, we’re not just helping them. We’re participating in something that matters to the heart of God Himself.”

—Paulo Lopes, president of ADRA International. He recently discussed whether helping others really makes a difference when the needs are so pressing and so many around the world. “My answer is unequivocal: ‘Yes,’ he said. ‘Now more than ever.’”

148

The number of preachers needed as speakers in 220 sites in the upcoming evangelistic series across the Solomon Islands in July. The meetings are part of the July-August Trans Pacific for Christ initiative, where speakers are scheduled to share Bible truth in more than 1,100 sites across the Trans Pacific Union Mission of the Adventist Church. Besides the Solomon Islands, the island church region includes American Samoa, Fiji, Kiribati, Nauru, Niue, Samoa, Tokelau, Tonga, Tuvalu, and Vanuatu.

“In times of grief, people naturally ask questions about life, death, and eternity. When those questions arise, the message of Christ becomes incredibly meaningful.”

—A Seventh-day Adventist worker serving in Funeral Ministry, a special lay-led and volunteer-driven service that seeks to provide funeral and burial assistance to church members with no family support in northern Thailand. In the predominantly Buddhist culture of the area, families often measure dignity in death by the respect shown during funeral rites. Now Adventists are using funerals as witnessing opportunities.

“Technology is not the mission, but it empowers and carries the mission. So our task as leaders is not to run IT; our task is to ensure that technology is designed . . . and funded to serve mission well.”

—Ryan Micua, IT director of the Southern Asia-Pacific Division during a presentation at the regional leadership summit in Bangkok, Thailand, March 4. Micua shared how his region is working in close partnership with the South Pacific Division to align their IT operations and collaborate to provide better services at a reduced cost.

ADVENTIST REVIEW NEWSLETTER

Do you want to keep up with what is happening in our church? If you want to receive our weekly newsletter that features news, inspirational stories, videos, and more, sign up today.



400

The number of church leaders in the Southern Asia-Pacific Division who recently committed to support the OneVoice27 initiative across their region. OneVoice27 seeks to commemorate 2,000 years since Jesus' baptism and the beginning of His ministry around the world. The project envisions using all church media, leaders, and members to make an impact around the world in September 2027 by sharing God's message as has never been done before.

“In a secular age, people aren't asking, ‘Is Christianity true?’ as much as they are asking, ‘Is it meaningful, is it good, and does it belong in my world?’ Our calling is not simply to give answers, but to embody a faith that can be experienced before it is explained.”

—Bledi Leno, who was recently appointed director of the Center for Secular and Post-Christian Mission. The center, one of six Global Mission Centers operated by the Office of Adventist Mission, helps Seventh-day Adventists seek to build bridges of understanding and friendship with people from major world religions and worldviews.

“Diet significantly impacts kidney health, and plant-based dietary patterns may offer a cost-effective strategy for chronic kidney disease prevention.”

—“Vegetarian Dietary Patterns and Diet-Related Metabolites Are Associated With Kidney Function in the Adventist Health Study-2 Cohort,” a study recently published in the *Journal of Renal Nutrition*. Researchers have found that vegan and pesco-vegetarian diets are associated with better kidney health compared to diets that include meat and dairy products. Diets that are strictly plant-based (vegan) as well as those that include fish (pesco-vegetarian) may offer protection against chronic kidney disease by helping the kidneys filter blood and remove waste more efficiently.



ADRA president Paulo Lopes says that presently, compassion matters more than ever. Here, connecting with a young child during a 2023 trip to Peru. Photo: ADRA International

YOUNG PEOPLE ARE AN INTEGRAL PART OF ADVENTIST MISSION, LEADERS SAY

In Spain an initiative encourages children to learn, engage in mission service.



Two boys smile during one of the activities at the I Will Go Kids in Sagunto, Valencia, Spain, March 21. Photo: Marcos Paseggi, *Adventist Review*

Marcos Paseggi, *Adventist Review*

Engaging in mission is not an adults-only venture—it includes teenagers and even children. Thus, young people should be not an afterthought but an integral part of the missionary enterprise.

This was the driving thought behind I Will Go Kids, an initiative that is transforming Seventh-day Adventist children and teenagers in Spain and beyond. During the March 20–22 I Will Go International Mission Congress at Sagunto Adventist College in Sagunto, Valencia, dozens of children learned more about Adventist mission, engaged in hands-on activities, and listened to deployed missionaries’ testimonies, as they prepare for a life of service wherever God may lead them.

Not Just Spectators

As hundreds of college students, lay church members, and church pastors and leaders participated in the I Will Go International Congress activities, a parallel program engaged dozens of their children and others in multiple activities and learning sessions. Children were issued a large “passport” with a photo and fill-in-the-blank and drawing pages.

During the event children learned about the joys and challenges of mission fields around the world, participated in group activities, and reacted to the experiences of other children growing up in missionary families. They were also able to talk to missionary families and ask questions about their service.

At select times they attended some of the presentations in the main hall, sitting in a special section arranged for them. As

they listened, they were invited to fill their passport with answers to specific questions about mission life and deployment.

“Often we think that children should, at best, hope to become missionaries one day,” organizers explained. “But as they prepare for whatever God has in store for them, children need to understand that they are already missionaries. At the same time, adults should apprehend the importance of planting the seed of service and mission as early as possible. Children who learn to love mission early are more likely to become lifelong missionaries,” they emphasized.

Well-rounded Kids

The carefully designed I Will Go Kids program is a byproduct of GPS Online, the brainchild of Majjo Roth, Children and Family Ministries director of the Spanish Union of Churches Conference. The initiative for 10- to 15-year-olds provides online extracurricular programs for Adventist children across Spain and has already connected, trained, and engaged hundreds of young ones in activities that focus on their wholistic development.

“The goal is not that children just become ‘good kids,’” Roth said. “The goal is that they become well-rounded, wholesome individuals. We don’t want our children just to survive—we’d like them to thrive.”

To achieve this, the focus of the program is on children’s emotional well-being, development of purpose, and spiritual identity. It also seeks to make them aware and develop significant relationships and resilience, Roth explained.

“Children and teens thrive when they can enjoy significant relationships and a sense of purpose,” she said. “And acts of service are essential to achieve that. In fact, in every study we conducted after implementing the program, we found out that service was the most transforming element in young people’s lives.”

Roth explained how experts agree that human beings need a sense of belonging, competence, and autonomy. Service—and mission service—scores high in all categories, she said. “When you serve, you feel competent,” she explained. “When you serve with others, you find belonging. And as you serve, you develop autonomy.”

From Mentees to Mentors

After several years of implementing GPS Online, Roth came across an issue she had not anticipated. “As the first participants of the program turned 16, many of them shared they loved the program so much they didn’t want to leave,” she shared.

Children leaders eventually signed a partnership with a company specializing in free-time mentoring, an officially recognized activity in Spain. This partnership allows GPS Online to facilitate certified training to many of those teens exiting GPS Online. During the I Will Go Kids program 25 of those certified teenage mentors helped coordinate and lead the daily activities.

“It’s a win-win situation,” Roth said. “Everyone focused on service, waiting to see how God will use them next.” 

“WE ARE CALLED TO DO SOMETHING THAT HAS NEVER BEEN DONE BEFORE”

400 Southern Asia-Pacific leaders commit to the OneVoice27 evangelistic initiative.

Marcos Paseggi, *Adventist Review*

Creative visual displays, worship music items, and laser-focused preaching sought to move 400 Seventh-day Adventist Church leaders from across the Southern Asia-Pacific Division (SSD) to action, as they pledged to “do something that has never been done before.” Their commitment took place at the closing of a presentation on the OneVoice27 project during the SSD Leadership Summit in Bangkok, Thailand, March 7.

“We are the generation that God has for a mission to this world,” said Alexander Ott, General Conference (GC) associate secretary and OneVoice27 liaison with the SSD. “We are His team, and we are doing something important together.”

What Is OneVoice27?

OneVoice27 is an initiative of the Adventist Church that seeks to commemorate 2,000 years since Jesus’ baptism and the beginning of His ministry. The project envisions using all church media, leaders, and members to make an impact around the world in September 2027 by sharing God’s message as has never been done before, leaders explained.

“The idea is to mobilize the Adventist family, moving forward initiatives that are contextualized to each region and culture,” they shared. “OneVoice27 aims to unite members, local churches, and media to simultaneously share a message of hope.”

During an introductory presentation Ott quoted the apostle Paul’s words in

2 Corinthians 5:13, calling Adventist leaders to “lose their minds to Christ,” that is to say, to dedicate all they have to proclaim God’s message in one loud voice in this generation. “This is the call for us—to open our minds and do something that has never been done before. It may take some sacrifice, but that is great leadership,” he emphasized. “Because OneVoice27 is a global evangelistic initiative that has not been done before.”

“THE IDEA IS TO MOBILIZE THE ADVENTIST FAMILY, MOVING FORWARD INITIATIVES THAT ARE CONTEXTUALIZED TO EACH REGION AND CULTURE,” THEY SHARED. “ONEVOICE27 AIMS TO UNITE MEMBERS, LOCAL CHURCHES, AND MEDIA TO SIMULTANEOUSLY SHARE A MESSAGE OF HOPE.”

Quoting the words of Adventist Church cofounder Ellen G. White, Ott called Adventists to “do something out of the common course of things.”* “Ellen White didn’t use the word ‘innovation,’ but this is

what she was talking about,” Ott explained. “This generation that God has today is called to innovate.”

What the Initiative Entails

Ott explained that the OneVoice27 initiative includes tapping the current power of media, which includes 5.66 billion people on social media, 7.2 billion smartphones, and 5 billion TV viewers. “If this is a reality, the innovation today is that we must do something with that. This is where people are—let us step into that space so we can speak with a loud voice.”

The goal of the project, Ott emphasized, is to “uplift Jesus as God and Savior, as the Messiah.”

A preparation phase will include a global prayer initiative throughout 2026, reflecting on Christ’s life by reading *The Desire of Ages*, by Ellen G. White, and studying the prophetic books of Daniel and Revelation. Every region of the world will seek to “build spiritual unity and dependence on the Holy Spirit before public proclamation,” Ott explained.

Regional Contextualization

During the presentation GC president Erton Köhler congratulated SSD leaders for embracing OneVoice27 wholeheartedly. “OneVoice is just an idea, a concept promoted from the General Conference, but you are the owners, the ones that [at regional and local levels] can decide how to implement the project,” he told them.



Group photo of General Conference and Southern Asia-Pacific Division leaders at the end of the March 7 presentation on the OneVoice27 project, in Bangkok, Thailand. Photo: Marcos Paseggi, *Adventist Review*

Arnel Gabin, SSD vice president for Nurture, Discipleship, Retention-Integrated Evangelism Lifestyle (NDR-IEL), agreed, pledging the region's "full support" to the world church initiative. At the same time, he reminded regional church leaders of the importance of moving forward together in unity as every regional and local church leader seeks ways to engage with the OneVoice27 project. "Get involved in united preparation and show a unified purpose," he told Adventist leaders.

Referencing the billions of people who haven't even heard the name of Jesus, Gabin said that such reality calls Adventists "to deeper sacrifice, strategic mission, and urgent action." He explained, "We cannot simply repeat what has already been done; we must use all possible means . . . to reach those who still haven't heard the everlasting gospel."

Gabin called every church region to contextualize the initiative to their territories, even while keeping with the overall goal of the initiative. At the same,

he added, "OneVoice27 calls us to move together in intentional disciple-making." In that regard, he explained, directives from the division office seek that each region moves forward, not working independently but harmoniously. "This is the spirit of OneVoice27," he said.

A Loud Voice

According to Köhler, the mandate of the Adventist Church is based on the book of Revelation, in which "we have a message that can reach, impact, and transform the world—the three angels' messages—that the Lord has entrusted this church." In that sense, he emphasized, there's a golden thread across the book of Revelation that time after time calls God's people to proclaim the last message "with a loud voice."

Such mandate is also based on Adventist history, Köhler added, as Adventist pioneers "sold all they had to proclaim the message with a loud voice. They gave the best of their time and talents, and even gave their lives, to announce it

with a loud voice." Now, he said, it is our turn to proclaim the message with a loud voice. "Are we doing it?" Köhler asked regional leaders.

Köhler shared that when he thinks of OneVoice27, in his mind he can sum it up with one word—boldness. "OneVoice is boldness—doing something that has not been done before . . . doing more than we have done before."

That boldness includes being bold in faith, bold in courage, bold in investments, and bold in initiatives, he said. "The Lord is able to do things beyond our imagination, so let us move forward by faith," Köhler said. "We can't see the path? Let's start to move forward, and the Lord will open the way. We don't have money? Let's move forward, and the Lord will provide. Our leadership is not well prepared? Let's move forward by faith doing what we can, and the Lord will open doors, because what is impossible for us is possible for God." 

* Ellen G. White, *Evangelism* (Washington, D.C.: Review and Herald Pub. Assn., 1946), p. 123.

PROTESTING THE CHURCH

How to respond
when the church
does wrong





Shane Anderson

In my three decades of denominational employment I've seen my share of church scandals. I remember the local conference officer who thought a little redirecting of conference funds into "more profitable ventures" would provide more revenue for the church (it didn't). Then there was the union official who unilaterally flouted significant church policies, in part because he knew the only constituents who could hold him accountable were handpicked by his cronies. And I'll not soon forget the high-level leader who extolled the virtues of chastity and integrity, all while nurturing an illicit relationship on the side. An error-free church we are not.

In light of such things, what should the thoughtful church member do? Is there a proper way to “protest” when church leaders do wrong? Some choose to ignore the situation, hoping things will improve over time. Others choose to respond but do so in such poor fashion that the situation escalates rather than resolves. In extreme cases, improper intervention can lead to lasting chaos, the splitting of churches, and to members becoming so sufficiently diverted that Jesus and the three angels’ messages are no longer shared with those who desperately need both. Poorly addressed errors in church leadership rarely lead to beneficial results.

What Not to Do

I contend that successfully protesting (and hopefully resolving) mistakes made by church leaders often begins with avoiding some common pitfalls. Consider the following three points:

1. Avoid automatically assuming you understand the error that has been made—or that an error has been made at all. What you think (or heard, or read, etc.) the church leader did may be entirely true! But never assume that secondhand reports or even what you witnessed personally are all there is to the story. Anyone who’s done jury duty knows that even legitimate eyewitnesses to a crime can bring substantially different viewpoints concerning the same situation. Be wise, and reserve judgment until the facts are fully fleshed out.

2. Resist using social media and other public means to broadcast your thoughts on a developing situation (and be wary of what others say there, as well).

Proverbs 18:8 says, “The words of a talebearer are like tasty trifles”—in other words, we humans tend to love juicy gossip! And what could be juicier than a church leader gone wrong? But Proverbs 16:28 also says, “A perverse man sows strife, and a whisperer separates the best of friends.” Paul goes even further and lists gossipers (“whisperers,” in the NKJV) in the same breath as murderers and the sexually immoral (Rom. 1:29, 30)—all examples of those who will not inherit heaven. To gossip is therefore a serious sin and can also derail resolution efforts quickly.

I sadly recall one time a legitimate wrong had been committed by a church leader, but nothing on the scale of what the gossip circuit was claiming. Laypeople started calling for heads to roll when only hands needed slapping. This ultimately, and very unfairly, damaged the church’s overall leadership reputation among the general membership. Moreover, one bad decision, unfairly inflated by the rumor mill, can make it that much more difficult for anyone in the church to

lead in the future. Please think twice before adding your voice to that denigration process.

3. Do not use tithe as a weapon. For more than a century now, disheartened Adventists the world over have occasionally decided that one effective way to protest the ills at the conference/union/division office is to withhold tithe. But in my opinion this is an exceedingly poor choice for at least two reasons.

First, it rarely, rarely works. Early in my ministry some influential and angry members in the conference assured me that “the only language those scoundrels at the office understand is money!” But I’ve since learned that few are the tithe payers who, by withholding their tithe, can produce enough fiscal pressure to cause church leadership to budge on this or that issue. Adventism is a bona fide global, interconnected entity that is generally not monetarily beholden unto even hundreds of members withholding their tithe. And let’s be consistent: If a conference/union/division leader really is as bad as tithe withholders say they are, they will likely not be swayed (even if substantial financial pressure is brought to bear), if for no other reason than sheer stubbornness and egotism.

Second, even if tithe withholding does “work” and erring leaders become more open to change, the collateral damage to innocents along the way will likely be real. When tithe totals drop, other Christlike leaders at that level of the church must adjust for it. This often manifests in ministries and/or pastors being cut—ministries and pastors that nearly always have nothing to do with the issue that prompted the withholding of tithe in the first place. To me, this has both real-world and eternal implications.

Imagine, for instance, that a church is planning to plant a new church in an unentered area as soon as they receive a promised new pastoral staff member. But because of member angst elsewhere in the conference over a genuinely bad decision an officer makes, tithe is withheld, and that new pastor never materializes.¹ I am fully convinced that two parties will be held accountable in the final judgment for the subsequently lost harvest: the erring conference officer, and those who withheld their tithe.²

Steps to Healthy Resolution

Blessedly, in my experience there are at least four steps that can be taken to protest and often resolve negative situations caused by church leaders.

1. Pray for the Spirit and wisdom. Please don’t mistake this for cliché; it is instead essential. Church leaders, when in the wrong, can cause a great deal of collateral damage. But so can dealing inappropriately with their offenses. We need the filling of God’s Holy Spirit and His subsequent gift of wisdom if we are to navigate leadership issues His way.

2. Determine to love the erring leader as Christ loves them. Those who skip this step are sadly numerous—and easy to spot. They’re the ones who protest as the world does, fostering division, making up pejorative nicknames for the leaders they don’t like, freely accusing them of all manner of evils and mistakes, etc.

In startling contrast with this, Scripture tells us to “love your enemies, do good to those who hate you” (Luke 6:27). And Ellen White reflected that “I call to mind the shepherd hunting the lost sheep, and [the story of] the prodigal son. I want those parables to have their influence upon my heart and mind. I think of Jesus—what love and tenderness He manifested for erring, fallen man; and then I think of the severe judgment one pronounces upon his brother who has fallen under temptation, and my heart becomes sick.”³

Clearly the same attitude Jesus has toward sinners—of even being willing to lay down His life for them—ought to be ours as well. The fact that a church leader is to be rightly held to a higher standard does not give us permission to treat them with scorn or even apathy. Instead, self-sacrificing love is the minimum standard for those who would intervene when a church leader fails to exemplify Christ.

3. Appropriately ask others for clarity. To some, this step may sound suspiciously like gossip. Rightly done, however, it is not gossip,⁴ but rather an honest expression of a desire to lovingly address a potentially serious situation. Because of their broader duties to often large constituencies, there can be significant relational distance between the average church leader and a church member. That distance can easily skew perception, leading even sincere members to perceive wrong behavior where none exists.

To avoid this error, as well as to conserve time and emotional energy, I have found that a simple question asked of other Christians who are (a) mature and capable of godly discretion and (b) situated such that they are likely to know the answer to my questions can help set me on the right path. And yes, I have at times personally found that this step reveals a misunderstanding, that the leader is not guilty of error, and that my quest is over. But other times it has indicated that a wrong likely has been committed.

4. Implement the steps of Matthew 18 to the best of your ability. Again, any pagan can run to their favorite digital platform and cast accusations against public leaders. But Christians are to be of an entirely different caliber. In my experience, Matthew 18:15-17, while not directly applying to public sins, nonetheless applies in principle to nearly all conflict resolution situations.⁵ This means that the work to address an erring leader should aim to follow at least three ideals.

First, solve the problem in the smallest possible sphere, involving the least number of people. This helps keep the pressure in the situation more manageable, as well as safeguards the church’s public reputation, when that is appropriate. Second, when expanding the accountability circle, as far as it depends on you, choose only the highest spiritual-quality people. And third, remember that the purpose is always to redeem whenever possible. Restoration, not crucifixion, is the goal.

When implementing the first part of Matthew 18, speak directly to the leader in question, preferably via an in-person meeting, secondarily through a video call or a phone call, or least preferably, via email (as it’s the least personal and conveys the least amount of relational nuance). When communicating via email, make the email only as long as it absolutely must be (unnecessarily long emails often simply don’t get read). If the wrong was done by a committee, ask to communicate directly to the chair of that committee.

Remember to always approach leaders at this stage as if they are *not* guilty of what you suspect them of and frame your concerns accordingly. Local culture, of course, comes into play here, and how one approaches church leaders can vary dramatically from country

RESTORATION, NOT CRUCIFIXION, IS THE GOAL.

Illustration by Luisa Jung



GODLY EFFORTS BY GODLY PEOPLE WILL EVENTUALLY LEAD TO GODLY CHANGE.

to country. In the United States, after pleasantries have been exchanged, I would preface my questions with something like “Thank you so much for your time. I’m speaking with you today because of something that happened recently, and I wanted to come directly to you to see what your understanding of it is.”

Notice my message here: I am coming on my behalf, not as part of a gang of disgruntled members; I am coming to the leader rather than consulting the rumor mill; I value the leader’s understanding and am looking for their viewpoint rather than forcing my own. These techniques can help leadership be more at ease, knowing that I am looking first for dialogue and comprehension rather than prosecution.

Does this kind of direct but empathetic conversation take courage? Can a leader, lovingly confronted, nonetheless become defensive? Yes, and yes! But in dozens of situations over my years in ministry, I have always found this first step in Matthew 18 to be well worth doing. During times I’ve courteously confronted a church leader, they have usually been glad I respected them enough to speak directly with them. At times I’ve learned the rumored error never happened or was decidedly different from what I’d thought. Other times, leaders have admitted the wrong, apologized, and proceeded to rectify the situation. And I’ve found that even if the situation is not resolved, I nonetheless gained valuable information that would later help bring resolution.⁶

If the leader is guilty and unrepentant, the principle in Matthew 18 is next to widen the circle. I recommend adding to your conversation with the erring leader one or two mature elders from somewhere in the leader’s field of influence. Meet as many times as needed, if progress is being made.

If progress stops, the next step is to broaden the sphere to include people in genuine authority. Nearly all unions in the Seventh-day Adventist Church have official grievance resolution guidelines⁷ that should be adhered to. They will help you know more precisely what the application of Matthew 18 looks like in your part of the world field. Following them faithfully will help others to trust in your intervention efforts and will provide the greatest likelihood of healthy resolution.

But What If...

But what if all your efforts don’t lead to resolution? From my experience, I see at least two possibilities.

First, it is possible you are in the wrong. If you have exhausted Matthew 18 as well as the local grievance resolution policy, and the situation is still not resolved to your satisfaction, it may be because you have been in error and need to back off. Never be afraid to

listen to those responding to the situation differently than you, particularly as the steps of resolution progress and the number of people involved expands. Heaven’s wisdom can still be found among God’s people. Be mindful that you’re not outside of it.

Second, in rare instances, an erring leader has such a tight hold politically on their field of influence that they have few fears of accountability from someone of your status. What should you do then?

I have been in this situation before. It is unpleasant, and I do not know of any easy solutions. But I do know at least three things. First, God is not dead; He still sees, still cares, and is actively working out a solution, no matter how hopeless things may seem. He can bring good out of any situation (see Rom. 8:28). Second, if the situation truly is sufficiently serious, don’t give up. Continue to pray regularly for the erring leader. Continue to look for loving ways to hold them accountable. And third, if they are an elected leader in the church (and assuming you’ve already completed the resolution steps detailed earlier to the best of your ability), lovingly and respectfully make your voice heard at the next election cycle. It can take years. But in my experience, godly efforts by godly people will eventually lead to godly change.

Courage, Wisdom, and Love

Appropriately protesting errors by church leaders is rarely easy. But if we ask for Christ’s courage, wisdom, and love, even the most complicated situations have a good chance of resolution. May God grant us this virtuous trio, that we might rightly meet the challenges outside—and inside—His church in these last days. **A**

¹ I phrase this scenario as a hypothetical. Rest assured, there are real stories of this I could tell from the past 30 years, were anonymity not a concern.

² It may be tempting for some to argue here about whether the “storehouse” mentioned in Scripture (Mal. 3:10) is indeed the local conference office. To me, this point, while mildly interesting in some contexts, is ultimately irrelevant. The facts are that, administratively speaking, the Adventist Church is currently designed to fund local ministries through a conference-based structure. One therefore cannot redirect tithe without impacting negatively—and unpredictably—other local ministries that are innocent of wrongdoing.

³ Ellen G. White, *Manuscript Releases* (Silver Spring, Md.: Ellen G. White Estate, 1993), vol. 16, p. 339.

⁴ I heard one wise saint define gossip as “talking with those who are not part of the solution to the problem.”

⁵ There are exceptions to this. For instance, if the leader in question has potentially broken the law in serious fashion (through physical violence, sexual assault, money laundering, etc.), then legal authorities most likely need to be involved as soon as possible.

⁶ It also gave me the helpful qualification of being able to say I had spoken directly with the accused leader should this become a point of contention later.

⁷ To find these guidelines, contact the secretary of your local union or conference, who will most likely also have access to them.

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THE BIBLE ONLY AND ELLEN WHITE

Adventists, *sola scriptura*, and the Spirit of Prophecy

What is *sola scriptura*, and how does Ellen White fit in?

Many might wonder, after more than 500 years, whether the classic Protestant stand on *sola scriptura*, or “the Bible and the Bible only,” is still relevant. In fact, many Christians no longer believe in the principle of *sola scriptura*—that the Bible should be our only authority for faith and practice. What about the discoveries of science regarding evolution, and psychology’s contention that gender is relative?

There’s no question that we have made remarkable advances in science and many other areas of knowledge. Some even point to this as a sign that we are living near the end of earth’s history. Clearly, though, society has not always used that knowledge positively. Sometimes it has been devastatingly destructive. But the Bible has withstood repeated attacks, such as those of Voltaire, who predicted the Bible’s demise, but whose home, reportedly, was later used to house Bibles!*

The Bible itself unequivocally urges us to trust its pages: “All Scripture is given by inspiration of God, and is profitable for doctrine, for reproof, for correction, for instruction in righteousness, that the man of God may be complete, thoroughly equipped for every good work” (2 Tim. 3:16, 17).

In answer to two disciples who no longer believed He could be the Messiah because of His crucifixion, Jesus, rather than revealing Himself openly as risen from the dead,

showed them “in all the Scriptures” that it was “necessary for the Christ to suffer these things and to come into His glory” (Luke 24:26, 27, NASB). Thus, He shows that the Bible is the only authority for faith and practice. God has protected the Bible through the centuries because it alone can “make you wise for salvation through faith which is in Christ Jesus” (2 Tim. 3:15).

Archaeological findings continue to provide evidence of the Bible’s historical reliability. The accurate fulfillment of Bible prophecies through history up to the present also witnesses to its divine

relativism and information overload, *sola scriptura* preserves the primacy of God’s revealed Word as the final test of truth and faithfulness.

How should we understand the inspiration of Ellen White’s writings and their relation to the Bible principle of *sola scriptura*? She herself referred to her writings as the “lesser light” shining on the “greater light” of the Bible. They were given to help us understand the Bible and God’s will for us. They can never replace Bible study, nor are they in any sense an addition to the Bible. The Bible remains the supreme

In an age of relativism and information overload, *sola scriptura* preserves the primacy of God’s revealed Word as the final test of truth and faithfulness.

inspiration and trustworthiness. No other book comes close to God’s timeless wisdom found in Scripture. Only the Bible provides a God-given norm amid competing authorities—tradition, culture, experience, or charismatic leadership. Seventh-day Adventist doctrines arose through careful Bible study, letting Scripture interpret Scripture. In an age of

authority for doctrine, an infallible revelation of God’s will, and a trustworthy record of God’s acts in history. **✚**

* https://www.biblesociety.org.uk/content/get_involved/bible_sunday/2016_resources/Bible-Sunday-Sermon-notes.pdf

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Job's Wife

Lessons in
grief, pain, and
mercy amid
unspeakable loss

Claudio and
Pamela Consuegra

The book of Job is one of Scripture's most searching explorations of innocent suffering. While much attention is given to Job himself—his patience, his protests, his perseverance—standing beside him in the ashes is another figure whose pain is just as real but whose voice is heard only once: Job's wife. Her brief appearance belies a deep reservoir of sorrow, grief, and unanswered questions, but her story invites reflection on how God meets those who suffer imperfectly and speak from wounded hearts.

As we read the first chapter of Job, we're quickly told of their immense and swift losses. In a matter of moments their world collapsed. They lost their livelihood, their social standing, and most devastatingly, all 10 of their children. What we seem to forget is that Job's wife endured the same cascade of losses as her husband. The deaths of all 10 children are often described through Job's anguish, but the mother's grief would have been no less intense. Her identity, hopes, and daily life were torn apart alongside Job's. Each child represented a relationship, a memory, a future abruptly cut off. Grief of that magnitude does not fade quickly; it compounds.

But when Job is later struck with painful sores from head to foot, his wife watches her husband's physical and emotional agony unfold before her eyes. She is not an observer of suffering; she is immersed in it. Whatever faith she once shared with Job is now being tested by relentless loss and the apparent silence of God.

The book of Job is a narrative of suffering that refuses easy answers. While Job's endurance and arguments dominate the text, his wife appears briefly and vanishes just as quickly. Yet her short presence opens a window into a different kind of suffering, one marked not by speeches and debates, but by quiet endurance, broken by a single cry of anguish. Job's wife shows what faith looks like when it is crushed by loss and left without explanation.

The book of Job is
a narrative of suffering
that refuses easy answers.



Judgment Suspended

It is a common belief that the most difficult, painful death to bear is that of a child, but studies show that the death of a spouse can be even more difficult.* This is not to minimize the pain felt by the parents when a child dies, but research suggests that at least the parents have each other as they make this painful journey through their loss or grief. When a spouse dies, however, the surviving spouse does not have the other partner to turn to. Job lost everything, but he still had his wife. His wife lost everything, and she was losing her husband, too. She watched her husband descend into physical torment. The man who once protected and provided now sat disfigured in ashes, scraping his sores. She lived in the tension of loving someone she could not heal, praying to a God who did not seem to answer, and unlike Job, she is never shown receiving visitors, counsel, or even an outlet for her pain.

In the biblical narrative Job's wife speaks only once: "Do you still hold fast to your integrity? Curse God and die!" (Job 2:9). This line has often earned her harsh judgment, as if she were merely tempting Job to sin or encouraging him to give up his belief in God. Yet read through the lens of grief, her words sound less like calculated rebellion and more like raw pain, anguish, and despair. Her statement can be understood as the cry of someone who sees no end to suffering. In her mind Job's integrity has not protected their family. Faith, as she understands it at that moment, has not brought relief. Death appears to her as the only escape from unbearable pain, both for Job and, perhaps, for herself. Rather than a philosophical argument against God, her words resemble the anguished speech of a broken person who has reached emotional exhaustion.

Through the ages Jewish sages and Christian Bible scholars have accused Job's wife of being the devil's instrument to tempt Job. She is compared to Eve, who led her husband, Adam, to fall. She is called ignorant, rebellious, and unkind to her husband. But strikingly, God never directly addresses Job's wife in the book. Later He sharply corrects Job's friends for speaking wrongly about Him, but Job's wife is excluded from that rebuke. She is neither condemned by God nor punished in the narrative. Unlike Job's friends, Job's wife receives no divine censure. The text is silent about any judgment against her.

This silence is significant. It suggests that God recognizes the difference between defiant evil and grief-stricken speech. Her words, though flawed, arise from pain rather than malice. God's mercy is often revealed not only in what He says but also in what He chooses not to say. At the end of the book, when Job's fortunes are restored, Job's wife is implicitly included in that restoration. Job again has a household, children, and a future. While the text does not focus on her role, it strongly implies that she continues life alongside Job, participating in the renewed blessings. God does not cast her aside for her moment of despair; instead, He allows her story to continue within the larger arc of restoration.

A God With Big Shoulders

As a hospice chaplain and pastor, I (Claudio) stood many times by the side of a dying patient and their loved ones. Little by little their life vanished, like sand between their fingers, until it was no more. As a law-enforcement chaplain, I delivered the sad news of the tragic death of a young person, someone's child, or a spouse killed in an accident. Some reacted

Job's wife shows what faith looks like when it is crushed by loss and left without explanation.

with anger, others protected themselves in the cave of denial, while yet others melted in their pain at the news. I often heard words of anger toward the authorities, toward medical personnel, toward the deceased, and even toward God. Instead of defending God or chastising them for their anger, I encouraged them to talk to Him about their pain and their resentment. I have said the same thing to many people: *Talk to God; He has big shoulders and will listen to you.* He would rather hear your anger than have your silence. Job's narrative implies that God understands grief spoken without filter and does not treat it as a final verdict on a person's faith.

Job's wife represents those whose faith falters under extreme suffering. She does not offer a theological defense of God; she voices the question many dare not say aloud: *What is the point of faith when everything is gone?* The Bible does not erase her from the story for asking this question. Instead, it records her words honestly and moves forward without condemning her.

In this way Job's wife stands as a quiet testament to God's patience with the brokenhearted. Her pain is real, her response is human, and God's treatment of her, marked by restraint, silence, and eventual restoration, suggests a grace that makes room for grief. Her story reminds us that God's compassion extends even to those who speak from despair, and that moments of weakness do not have the final word in the hands of a merciful God.

Perhaps there's yet another lesson for us from the story of Job and his wife. Job's wife did not suffer *less* than Job; she suffered *differently*. We need to be very careful not to judge people in their sorrow. Each person grieves differently, and no one else can or should determine when or how they should grieve. For people whose loved one is dying of a terminal disease, they may go through anticipatory grief until their loved one dies. It is not unusual for them not to express their grief as visibly as others expect at a time like this; they have been grieving their loved one's illness all along. It doesn't mean they will never have moments when sorrow overwhelms them; it simply means that they started the journey through grief before their loved one died.

Of course, we also know the rest of the story. At the end, when God restores Job, He restores the household. New children are born, life is renewed, and the future opens again. Job's wife, though unnamed and unaddressed, is clearly part of this restored life. God does not remove her from the story for her moment of weakness. Instead, He allows her to live beyond it. Her inclusion in restoration shows that God's mercy is not limited to those who suffer "correctly." He does not demand perfect words from the broken. Instead, He allows space for grief, even when that grief speaks in ways that fall short of trust.

The rest of the story for us who have lost a loved one, whether to illness, tragic accidents, or natural causes, will not see its positive end until resurrection morning. No newborn will replace the child we lost. No new spouse can take the place of the one who died. But when we are finally reunited, for eternity, the end of the story will finally be better than its beginning.

Job's wife represents those who lack eloquent prayers when tragedy strikes. She speaks once, and her words are messy, painful, and uncomfortable. Yet Scripture preserves them, acknowledging that suffering often strips faith of polish and leaves only raw honesty.

Her story reminds us that God's patience extends to those who cry out in confusion, who falter under the weight of sorrow, and who cannot see past their pain. In the end Job's wife stands, not as a villain, but as a witness to a God who remains present, even when faith breaks under grief. ❧

* <https://grievewellblog.wordpress.com/2017/06/22/a-theory-of-grief-relativity/>

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THE NEUROSCIENCE OF FORGIVENESS



Where Scripture meets science

I've been concerned about my broken relationship with friends from childhood that ended years ago because of silly disagreements. Recently I started reading about what science says about forgiveness, and I would love to get your take on it.

When Paul wrote to the Ephesian church, “Instead, be kind to each other, tenderhearted, forgiving one another, just as God through Christ has forgiven you” (Eph. 4:32),¹ he was issuing more than a moral directive. Modern neuroscience suggests he was prescribing a pathway to psychological liberation and relational healing that literally rewires our brains.

The Brain on Unforgiveness

When we experience betrayal or hurt, our brains respond with a cascade of stress hormones. The amygdala, our brain's threat-detection center, fires up and sounds the alarm. Cortisol floods our system. Our bodies enter a state of chronic stress when we rehearse grievances and nurture resentment. Neuroimaging studies show that recalling offenses activates the same neural pathways associated with physical pain—the anterior cingulate cortex and the insula light up as though we're experiencing the wound all over again.

This isn't just metaphorical suffering. Research published in the *Journal of Behavioral Medicine* demonstrates that chronic unforgiveness correlates with elevated blood pressure, increased cardiovascular problems, compromised immune function, and higher rates of anxiety and depression. When we hold grudges, we're essentially poisoning our neurochemistry, bathing our brains in stress hormones designed for only short-term threats.

The Healing Chemistry of Forgiveness

Forgiveness triggers a dramatically different neurological response. Studies using

functional MRI scans reveal that when people engage in genuine forgiveness, activity decreases in areas associated with rumination and emotional pain while increasing in regions linked to empathy and perspective-taking—particularly the prefrontal cortex and the precuneus—often considered a hub for the brain's default mode network (DMN).

The act of forgiveness releases oxytocin, often called the “bonding hormone,” which promotes feelings of trust and connection. It also triggers the release of endorphins and dopamine, creating a sense of relief and even pleasure. Fred Luskin's groundbreaking forgiveness research at Stanford University² shows that people who practice forgiveness experience measurable reductions in anger, stress, and hurt, alongside increases in optimism and hopefulness.

Perhaps most remarkably, forgiveness strengthens the prefrontal cortex's regulatory control over the amygdala. In practical terms this means that the more we practice forgiveness, the better our brains become at managing emotional reactivity and choosing thoughtful responses over impulsive reactions. We're literally building neural pathways that make grace more automatic and resentment less reflexive.

Forgiveness and Relational Restoration

The neurological benefits extend beyond individual healing into relational transformation. When we forgive, we activate what neuroscientists call “mentalizing networks”—brain regions that help us understand others' mental and emotional

states. This increased empathic capacity creates space for genuine reconciliation.

Interestingly, the neural benefits of forgiveness don't require the offender's repentance or even presence. Studies show that unilateral forgiveness—the kind Jesus modeled from the cross—still produces psychological and physiological benefits for the forgiver. This validates Christ's teaching that forgiveness liberates the forgiver even more than the forgiven.

Biblical Wisdom, Biological Design

The biblical mandate to forgive “just as God through Christ has forgiven you” connects divine grace with human neurobiology. As we receive God's forgiveness, we're experiencing not just spiritual renewal but also neurological recalibration—our brains literally learning a new pattern of grace.

Forgiveness isn't weakness or denial. It's a courageous choice to rewire our neural circuitry toward peace rather than perpetuating cycles of pain. When Jesus taught us to forgive, He was showing us the pathway home to ourselves, to each other, and ultimately to God. **✚**

¹ All Scripture references are from the *Holy Bible, New Living Translation*, copyright © 1996, 2004, 2015 by Tyndale House Foundation. Used by permission of Tyndale House Publishers, Inc., Carol Stream, Illinois 60188. All rights reserved.

² See Fred Luskin's *Forgive for Good*.

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OUR GREAT HIGH PRIEST

In heaven Satan was next to the Son of God. But he yielded to the desire for self-exaltation, and was expelled from the heavenly courts. He came to this earth, to exercise over man his debasing power. This power increased with the ages, but its evil was not recognized, and God could not arbitrarily condemn its author. Satan's work was a deadly peril to the universe, but for the security of the world and of the government of heaven, he must be allowed to develop his principles in their true light.

Christ came to this world to save men from death; and from the manger to the cross His way was disputed by Satan. The enemy filled the minds of the Jews with hatred against their Redeemer. He rested not until Christ hung on the cross.

But in carrying out his enmity toward Christ till he crucified Him, hung Him on the cross of Calvary, with bruised body and broken heart, Satan completely uprooted himself from the affections of the universe. Christ's death silenced forever the charge that with God self-denial was impossible. It was seen that God denied Himself because of His love for mankind.

More than we could possibly endure, Christ endured in our behalf. Sinless to the last, He died for us. Justice demanded not merely that sin be pardoned; the death penalty must be met. The Saviour has met this demand. His broken body, His gushing blood, satisfied the claims of the law. Thus

Where the death penalty was met

Ellen G. White

He bridged the gulf made by sin between earth and heaven. He suffered in the flesh, that with His robe of righteousness He might cover the defenseless sinner.

To resist Satan's temptations is no easy task. It calls for a firm hold on God. Christ has met every temptation which Satan can bring against man. He is the Way, the Truth, and the Life. In His strength man can keep the law of God.

Christ was crucified, but in wondrous power and glory He rose from the tomb. He took in His grasp the world over which Satan claimed to preside, and restored the human race to favor with God. And at this glorious completion of His work, songs of triumph echoed and re-echoed through the unfallen worlds. Angel and archangel, cherubim and seraphim, joined in the chorus of victory.

Christ is able to save to the uttermost all who come to God by Him. He ever liveth to make intercession for us. In earnest appeals the cross continually proffers to the sinner complete expiation. In loving

invitation Christ lifts His voice, saying, "Whosoever will, let him take the water of life freely."

As you draw near the cross of Calvary, you see love that is without a parallel. As by faith you grasp the meaning of the sacrifice made on that cross, you see yourself a sinner, condemned by a broken law. This is repentance. As you come with humble heart, you find pardon; for Jesus stands before the Father, continually offering a sacrifice for the sins of the world. He is the minister of the true tabernacle, which the Lord pitched, and not man. The typical offerings of the Jewish tabernacle no longer possess any virtue. A daily and yearly atonement is no longer necessary. But because of the continual commission of sin, the atoning sacrifice of a heavenly Mediator is essential. Jesus, our great high priest, officiates for us in the presence of God, offering in our behalf His shed blood.

And as Christ intercedes for us, the Spirit works upon our hearts, drawing forth prayer and penitence, praise and thanksgiving. The gratitude which flows from human lips is the result of the Spirit striking the chords of the soul, awakening holy music. ❧

Seventh-day Adventists believe that **Ellen G. White** (1827-1915) exercised the biblical gift of prophecy during more than 70 years of ministry. This excerpt is taken from *The Youth's Instructor*, Apr. 16, 1903.

WHICH WAY?

The way of the
Lamb versus
the dragon's
way of power

John Peckham



Just because one *can* does not necessarily mean that one *should*. Simply because one possesses the power to force a preferred outcome does not warrant that one use that power to do so.

Consider a very powerful district attorney who genuinely seeks justice, but decides to use power and authority to coerce others to plant evidence and intimidate witnesses to guarantee a guilty verdict against someone the attorney knows—beyond a shadow of a doubt—is guilty. In such a scenario justice is not served, but undermined. One cannot achieve justice by injustice.

The way of the Lamb—the way of unselfish love—is diametrically opposed to the Machiavellian claim that the ends justify the means. A judge might be able to secure an easy verdict by intimidation, but doing so would corrupt the very justice the judge claims to uphold.

Because God is perfectly loving and just, God does not exercise His power to coerce the wills of creatures and force universal obedience. The Bible unequivocally teaches that God is all-powerful (see, e.g., Jer. 32:17; Rev. 19:6), but God refuses to employ His power to override the wills of His creatures, because doing so would undermine love itself.

According to the story of redemption told throughout Scripture, the pinnacle of which is the Lamb's victory through the cross, God's triumph over evil hinges, not on the exercise of sheer power, but on unselfish love. In direct contrast to the dragon—who seeks to dominate by power and seeks to coerce the world to worship him—Christ overcomes evil as a Lamb who voluntarily suffers to defeat darkness and reconcile the world to Himself, rather than using His power to dominate creatures.

This is not incidental to God's victory over darkness, but stands at the very heart of God's triumph—the triumph of love.

Christ overcomes evil as a Lamb who voluntarily suffers to defeat darkness and reconcile the world to Himself, rather than using His power to dominate creatures.

The Temptation to “Win” the Wrong Way

Christ’s temptations in the wilderness (see Matt. 4; Luke 4) are often considered mere tests of individual morality. Yet they are far more than this; they tested *how* Jesus would fulfill His mission. Would He compromise goodness, truth, or love in order to accomplish good ends?

Each temptation highlights a legitimate end, but entices Christ to achieve it through illegitimate means.

Turning stones into bread would have assuaged Christ’s hunger, but using His own divine power to do so would have bypassed His trust and reliance on the Father (see Matt. 4:3, 4).

Even though it was framed in terms of faith in God’s promises, throwing Himself from the pinnacle of the temple would have amounted to presumption (see verses 5-7).

And by offering Christ all the kingdoms of the world, the devil craftily suggested Jesus could achieve His ultimate aim of saving the world without undergoing the suffering of the cross . . . simply by bowing the knee to Satan (see verses 8-10).

Of course, *had* Christ succumbed to such temptations, His mission to defeat evil and save the world would have failed. He could not redeem the world by abandoning the very principles of love that make redemption possible.

In each case the temptation offered a shortcut, a seemingly effective path to achieve good outcomes without the costly path of faithfulness. Each one offered a subtle invitation to exchange the way of the Lamb for the way of the dragon.

On one hand, the devil continually suggests that if the ends are good, the means can be justified. But according to the ethics of Scripture and according to the way of the Lamb—the way of unselfish love—the ends do not justify the means.

Christ possesses the sheer power to rule by force at any time, but doing so would undermine love itself.

Here and throughout His ministry Christ did not merely resist temptation—He revealed a vision of power fundamentally different from that of the world and that of the dragon and his minions (see, e.g., Rev. 12; 13).*

Gethsemane and the Sword

This contrast is also especially clear in Gethsemane as Christ’s crucifixion drew near. When the mob arrived with torches and weapons to take Christ by force, Peter drew his sword and struck out to defend Jesus (Matt. 26:47-56).

At first glance Peter’s action might seem justified. He acted to defend the innocent—not just any innocent person, but the Messiah Himself. What more righteous cause could there be?

But Jesus immediately rebuked him: “Put your sword in its place” (Matt. 26:52).

Jesus did not need the power of His disciples to defend Him. As He Himself stated, He could have summoned legions of angels (Matt. 26:53). His refusal to use force to escape the mob and

eventually avoid the cross stemmed not from any lack of power, but from His commitment to save the world in accordance with God’s perfect law of unselfish love.

Those who truly follow the Lamb *do* have a sword to wield, but not one of violence or coercion. Those who follow the Lamb are girded with the sword of the Word of God. The armor of faith (see Eph. 6:13-17) is designed, not for domination or worldly warfare, but for the spiritual battle over truth (an epistemic conflict). It is to be used against the devil’s relentless war of deception and unrelenting assault on both truth and love (cf. Rev. 12:9).

“My kingdom is not of this world,” Jesus later told Pilate. “If My kingdom were of this world, My servants would fight” (John 18:36).

Here and elsewhere, the manner in which Christ establishes His kingdom on earth reveals the nature of the kingdom itself.

Dragons dominate through fear and force. The Lamb suffers faithfully, absorbing violence so that truth and love may ultimately prevail. Christ chooses faithful, unselfish love over force, even though force would appear to secure immediate results in this world, for Christ’s kingdom cannot be established or sustained by methods that contradict God’s love.

Power Redefined at the Cross

The Romans wielded crucifixion not merely as a method of torture, but as a warning to all who would challenge Rome’s power. The cross was the ultimate symbol of defeat, shame, and powerlessness. Against this background, a crucified Messiah appeared to be foolish and scandalous (1 Cor. 1:18-25). Yet the apparent weakness of Christ manifested at the cross was in fact a display of power far greater than that of Rome, a display of the infinite power of divine love.

“The weakness of God is stronger than human strength” (1 Cor. 1:25, NIV). Through the cross, God the Son does not merely endure suffering; He demonstrates God’s very character of love and justice (see Rom. 3:25, 26; 5:8).

Eventually
all must
choose
between the
way of the
Lamb and
the way of
the dragon,
between
which there
is no middle
ground.

While the devil continually grasps for power and position, Christ does the opposite. Though He was “equal with God,” He “made Himself of no reputation, taking the form of a bondservant, and coming in the likeness of men” (Phil. 2:6, 7). “He humbled Himself and became obedient to the point of death, even the death of the cross” (verse 8).

The Lamb conquers by giving Himself to be slain. He defeats death through death (see Heb. 2:14). He overcomes the devil’s cult of power through violence and coercive force by the power of His unselfish, uncoercive love.

While we tend to think of power as the ability to control outcomes, to eliminate opposition and impose one’s will, Scripture paints a very different picture of *divine* power. Godly power remains faithful to truth, goodness, and love, and refuses to bend the knee to worldly pomp and power, even when doing so is extremely costly.

Scripture consistently teaches that God is all-powerful: He is the “Lord God Omnipotent” (Rev. 19:6), and nothing is too difficult for Him (Jer. 32:27). Thus God possesses the sheer power to compel obedience at any moment. Yet by His own free choice God refuses to govern the universe by using His power to coerce the will, choosing instead to consistently grant creatures the kind of freedom of the will that is necessary for a genuine love relationship.

At the cross and otherwise, Jesus thus stands as the ultimate revelation of God’s character. The Lamb’s refusal to coerce the will of His creatures is not a temporary strategy, but eternally expresses who God is: God *is* love (1 John 4:8, 16).

The Lamb’s Way and the Christian Life and Witness

This understanding of God’s power holds crucial implications for Christian life and witness.

Throughout history, especially in times of fear and polarization, Christians have been tempted to baptize the use of coercive power in the name of good outcomes. When anxiety rises, it becomes attractive to attempt to justify un-Christlike means for supposedly Christlike ends and to go along with those who wield coercive power in the name of Christ. But Scripture offers a stark warning: The way of the Lamb and the way of the dragon are fundamentally incompatible. You cannot follow the Lamb and at the same time behave like the dragon or condone those who do. Those who use the dragon’s way in Christ’s name are not following Christ. They act as wolves (or dragons) in sheep’s clothing.

When those who claim to be Christians abandon the Lamb’s way in favor of seeking domination, they might achieve short-term gains, but they do so at exceedingly great cost, because they compromise trust, distort their witness, and profoundly misrepresent the character of Christ.

The methods one employs are inseparable from the message one proclaims.

Jesus utterly rejects the world’s way of power. Eventually all must choose between the way of the Lamb and the way of the dragon, between which there is no middle ground.

Those who would truly follow Christ, and thus the way of the Lamb, cannot be in league with those who wield power to dominate others in Christ’s name and, by doing so, take the name of God in vain. Those who would follow Christ must beware of all who exalt power and sheer force, because following Christ entails rejecting any and all cults of power.

God will finally judge evil and set all things right. “God will wipe away every tear from their eyes; there shall be no more death, nor sorrow, nor crying. There shall be no more pain, for the former things have passed away” (Rev. 21:4).

This victory is assured not by worldly power, not by the way of the dragon, but by the Lamb’s way of unselfish, sacrificial love.

Since God rules only by patient, self-giving, faithful love, those who follow Him are called to live and bear witness the same way, eschewing the self-exalting way of the dragon that is so often deceptively cloaked in Christ’s name. Instead, they must humbly follow “the Lamb wherever He goes” (Rev. 14:4). 

* For much more on the way of the Lamb versus the way of the dragon in Revelation and the choice between them all will face before Christ’s second coming, see John C. Peckham, *God With Us: An Introduction to Adventist Theology* (Berrien Springs, Mich.: Andrews University Press, 2023), chap. 18.

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Photo: Pranav Gavali / Unsplash

To submit any type of original Adventist art (poetry, music, painting, drawing, film, photography, sculpture, etc.), please contact art@adventistreview.org. Submission does not guarantee publication. Creative works showcased do not imply an automatic endorsement of all works by featured artists.

THE HARVEST OF OUR LOSSES

Stewardship is an act of faith, deeply dependent on God's ability to bring life into dead and dying things. To steward well often means to lose: We steward time well by giving it up. We steward talents by using them, regardless of the cost in embarrassment or energy. We steward money by letting it go.

What is God asking you to put in the ground? The harvest of our losses, stewarded in the ground, brings a joy and abundance we cannot imagine. A life of stewardship becomes a life of planting in hope, losing intentionally for the sake of another, and waiting for the abundance of the promised resurrection. **¶**

—Madison Wilcox

The harvest of our losses, stewarded in the ground, brings a joy and abundance we cannot imagine.

POEM

PSALM 126

(paraphrased)

By Madison Wilcox

I
You are the soil
in which all dead things come alive.

We once watched the resurrection
of all that You had taken.
Every small thing You swallowed up
from our trembling hands
You returned to us
a hundredfold.

II
We once awakened
into a life we did not recognize
for the beauty of it.

We walked entranced
as You filled our tired hands
with sudden fruit.

You fed us a miracle;
It tasted like laughter.
We opened our mouths, and joy spilled out.

III
We hope our joy will one day fill the earth.
We hope someone will see it from afar
and say:

*Only God could make a man laugh like that.
Only God could raise up joy like that
out of a sorrow like this.*

Oh, we are glad.

IV
Return to us again
all that You have taken.

Resurrect again
all that we have buried
in the ground.

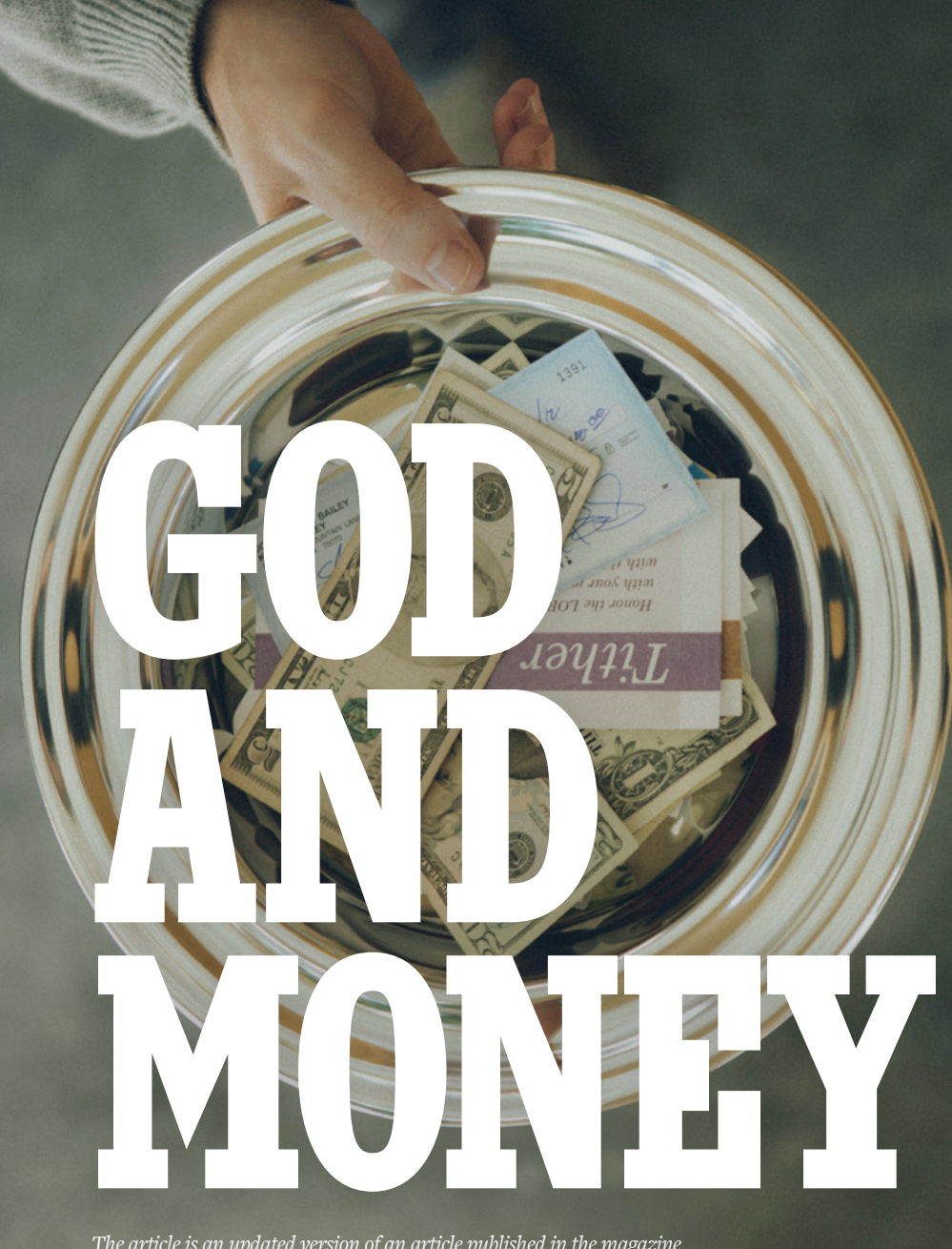
We know the harvest will soon overtake us
like a desert flood.

We know our present tears
are an omen
of a greater joy to come.

Yes, we will weep, and we will sow.
We will let the soil swallow
all that is in our hands.

For the harvest comes as surely
as the planting,
and the living as surely as the dying.
Soon it will spring up
like laughter in our mouths. **¶**

Madison Wilcox is a poet and lover of metaphor. She believes that to write poetry is to practice the art of incarnation—a practice that God, the ultimate poet, has perfected in Christ. You can read more of her work at psalmsrevisited.substack.com.

A hand is holding a silver bowl filled with US dollar bills and a purple envelope labeled 'Tithes'. The envelope has the text 'Honor the LORD with your tithes' and 'with your offerings'. The background is dark and textured.

GOD AND MONEY

The article is an updated version of an article published in the magazine WIND of the German Hanseatic Conference in 2024.

God and money—the combination sounds dubious and even incompatible. Bankers, accountants, and entrepreneurs deal with finances. Pastors, counselors, and theologians care about salvation, spiritual comfort, and God in our world. Where is the overlap?

Those interested in history can quickly list unfortunate connections between money and religion. In the ancient Near East, offerings were considered the basis of life for the gods and were used to finance powerful priestly castes—in Mesopotamia, Egypt, and Rome. Religion was big business and funded large temple economies.

Expensive letters of indulgence, requiem masses, and the trade in relics were a decisive factor in the economic life of the early and later Middle Ages, and ultimately led to the Protestant Reformation. God's approval and forgiveness could not be bought. They were not the result of an accounting transaction, according to the motto: I give God a monetary offering—and God blesses me spiritually and materially.

The problematic relationship between God and money is not limited to ancient or medieval history. Millionaire pastors of large megachurches, whether in the United States, Asia, or Africa, remain a visible reminder of the lucrative business of salvation.

What have tithe and offerings to do with my relationship with Jesus?

Gerald A. Klingbeil

What About Us?

After more than 30 years of service in the Seventh-day Adventist Church, I still can't afford a Porsche, and my bank account isn't exactly overflowing. As a lecturer at the Adventist university in Lima, Peru, I earned under US\$400 a month—and lived quite well on it. The church paid into my retirement fund in Germany, but a luxury lifestyle was not on the agenda. But most people in Peru earned significantly less than that. So wealth is about one's perspective.

During our 30 years of missionary service in South America, Asia, and North America, we learned a fundamental lesson as a family, no matter where we lived: The Adventist Church's solidarity-based tithing system, which finances pastors, teachers, missionaries, administrative staff, and much more, is unparalleled and deeply rooted in the tithing and offering system of the Bible. Of course, in the time of Solomon or Hezekiah, there were no structures and entities like those we have today, but tithing was the basis of life for the priests, Levites, temple singers, and temple servants who

served God and the people in the temple in Jerusalem or as spiritual ground staff in the towns and villages of Israel and Judah. Tithing is a fundamental biblical principle. We find tithing in texts prior to Israel's calling as God's people (Gen. 14:20; 28:22). We find it in legal texts (Lev. 27:30-33; Num. 18:25-32), in historical texts (Neh. 10:38, 39; 12:44; etc.), in prophetic sayings (Amos 4:4), and of course in the New Testament (Matt. 23:23; Luke 11:42).

Why 10 Percent?

The tithe, i.e., 10 percent of a year's profit or income, seemed to play an important role in God's plan to save this world and humanity. This raises the question: To what extent does God really need our money? And why exactly 10 percent?

Psalms 50:9-12 provides an answer to the first question: "I will not accept a bull from your house or goats from your folds. For every beast of the forest is mine, the cattle on a thousand hills. I know all the birds of the hills, and all that moves in the field is mine. If I were hungry, I would not tell you, for the world and its fullness are mine" (ESV).

The psalmist tells us that God owns the whole world and everything in it. "I don't need your money and your gifts," God tells us in His Word, "because everything belongs to Me anyway. But you need the tithe and offering system so that you can learn to trust Me every day."

At first glance the answer to the second question is unsatisfactory. It's 10 percent—because God said so!

A Test

God seems to take tithing seriously. After returning from exile, God spoke directly to His people through the prophet Malachi about tithing: "Will man rob God? Yet you are robbing me. But you say, 'How have we robbed you?' In your tithes and contributions. . . . Bring the full tithe into the storehouse, that there may be food in my house. And thereby put me to the test, says the Lord of hosts, if I will not open the windows of heaven for you and pour down for you a blessing until there is no more need" (Mal. 3:8-10, ESV).

These are drastic words that show us important principles beyond the specific historical situation following the return from exile. First, we cheat God when we do not give back 10 percent of the blessings we experience 100 percent of every day. Cheating is a criminal offense, and the reference to the curse shows us the seriousness of the situation. This is not a trivial infraction.

Second, there is a great deal of irony in the idea of wanting to cheat the Almighty. What kind of picture of God did those who hatched such a plan have? How does *my* picture of God influence my giving behavior? Am I trying to manipulate God—or do I find God too petty and pedantic in this regard?

Third, the tithe was to be brought to God's house (or temple) to accumulate enough food there. In the biblical context, tithe was usually given in kind and really served as food for priests, Levites, and their families. Today we use banking apps, online transfers, checks, or, quite "old-fashioned," bills in small envelopes to *return* our tithes—because we don't "pay" tithes. We "give" back something to the Giver of all good gifts that doesn't even belong to us, but to Him who has given us the strength, health, and abilities to earn money. Our

tithes do not go to the temple, either; they end up in accounts, where they are recorded, then passed on and used according to the criteria and principles we have established as a worldwide faith community.

Passing on is an important principle of giving because it helps us see others' needs. In this way a portion of our tithes flows proportionally through the various administrative units to regions of the world that are in a more precarious financial position than we are, either because they are unable to reach their surrounding communities or because they struggle financially. This principle of solidarity distinguishes us from many other denominations and is an important value.

God invites us to test His blessings in a very practical way.

Just Give It a Try

But back to Malachi. Many of us learn best when we try something practically, not just read about it. God invites us to test His blessings in a very practical way. When we give back to God with a joyful heart what belongs to Him anyway, we too can experience spiritual growth, abundance, and blessings. We learn that a living relationship with Jesus not only has spiritual dimensions but also permeates every aspect of my life—including my wallet and bank account. My unreserved and confident giving helps me to trust God more in all areas of my life. I learn not to rely on my bank account. I don't use money as a crutch for security or as a weapon to enforce my ideas. I give—and

then I can turn away with confidence, knowing that now it's God's turn and that of those who use this money responsibly to continue building God's kingdom.

Then I can experience miracles. My family and I have witnessed this not only in times of financial crisis—something that happened often in our worldwide ministry on five different continents—but also in moments of surprising blessing. God and money—they actually go together really well and are part of God's good plan to bless us and our world, and to change it in a lasting way.

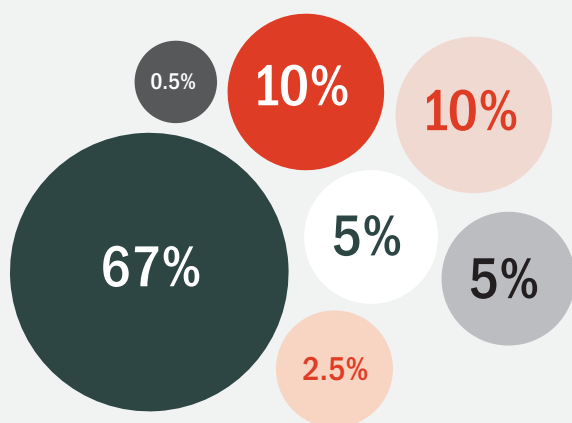
Where Does My Tithe Money Go?

The use of tithe is regulated by the General Conference's working policy. In line with biblical principles, the Seventh-day Adventist Church has determined that tithe money is always to be used to support all aspects of gospel ministry, including personnel (pastors, evangelists, administrative leadership, Bible teachers or professors at Adventist schools, etc.) and their living expenses (rent/mortgage, retirement funds, health-care costs, etc.).

Specific tithe allocations may vary slightly from division to division, depending on the number of institutions and entities that support the mission of the church. Here is an example from my perspective in the Hanseatic Conference in Germany, which is located in the territory of the Inter-European Division. The percentage numbers are from the total tithe income in our local conference.

The Adventist Church's solidarity-based tithing system, which finances pastors, teachers, missionaries, administrative staff, and much more, is unparalleled and deeply rooted in the tithing and offering system of the Bible.

Tithe distribution from the perspective of the Hanseatic Conference in Germany. Allocation percentages vary from division to division.



67% stays in the conference, funding:

- active pastors' salaries; departmental missional activities; administrative costs; conference magazine; partial funding of special conference Sabbath

10% to the Inter-European Division (EUD)

- sends some of those funds to the world field; supports other regional entities and specific mission projects

10% to the North German Union

- funds the administrative support system of the conferences; supports specific mission initiatives or helps to alleviate regional differences in financial strength

5% to the retirement plan of the church in Germany

- supports more than 600 retired ministers and their families

5% to Friedensau Adventist University (Theologische Hochschule Friedensau)

- trains future pastors; provides support through its various research; offers ongoing training for ministers and lay members

2.5% to Hope Media Europe

- offering evangelistic and lifestyle TV programming, reaching around 1.8 million viewers/month

0.5% to the Adventist boarding academy, Marlenhöhe

After nearly three years of service as a conference CFO, I am thoroughly convinced that our financial policies governing the use of tithes and offerings are solid. A yearly audit by the General Conference Auditing Service (GCAS) is an important element that involves the careful handling of sacred tithe funds. It offers transparency to our faithful giving members and control to our supervising boards.

God and money do go together. No, we can't use money to buy blessings, but tithes and offerings are part of a divine plan that helps us develop faithfulness, practice trust in the Giver of all good things, and offer growth to all those who are ready to start a faith journey with Him, who owns "the cattle on a thousand hills." 

Gerald A. Klingbeil, D.Litt., has served the Adventist Church for more than three decades internationally as a professor and editor. He now lives with his wife, Chantal, close to the beautiful city of Hamburg, Germany, where he serves as CFO of the Hanseatic Conference of Seventh-day Adventists.

TITHING

Why do we do it?

Many nonbelievers, convinced that churches are thinly veiled money-making machines, are skeptical of the offering plate at church. “If God is really omnipotent,” they ask, “then why does He need my money?” It’s a really good question.

1. Does God need our money in order to do His work on earth? (Ps. 50:10-12)

Every resource on this planet is at God’s disposal; it is clear that He doesn’t *need* our money any more than He *needs* us to run the church for Him. And if God doesn’t *need* us, it is logical to conclude that perhaps the tasks God gives us—including stewardship—are somehow put in place to benefit us. But how? What do we learn from returning a tithe?

The first mention of tithing in the Bible occurs in Genesis 14, when Abraham (then Abram) gave a tithe (10 percent) of his wealth to Melchizedek, king of Salem. The encounter between Abraham and this mysterious priestly figure sheds a lot of light on the purpose of tithing.

2. What did Melchizedek first present to Abraham before he received a tithe? (Gen. 14:18-20)

This episode in Abraham’s life prefigures the gospel: Melchizedek is a type of Christ; bread and wine are symbols of His sacrifice on the cross—as they are in the Communion service. It is instructive to notice that the priestly figure makes the first move in a reciprocal arrangement. Abraham’s tithe is a response to Melchizedek’s benevolence—just as our participation in the practice is a grateful response to what Christ has done for us.

Our participation in the practice is a grateful response to what Christ has done for us.

3. What similarities to the Melchizedek account do you find in the next biblical account of tithing, found in Genesis 28:10-22?

The ladder that bridged the gap between heaven and earth is also symbolic of Christ, who bridges the gap between fallen sinners and a holy God (see John 1:51). God first shows Jacob the vision, after which Jacob responds by pledging to tithe. Take a few moments to examine the story carefully and make a list of the lessons and blessings Jacob received. How have you received the same from God?

4. Some modern Christians insist that tithing is no longer to be practiced in the New Testament era. What does the New Testament say about this? (Matt. 23:23; 2 Cor. 9:6-13)

5. Malachi informs us that holding back our tithes is an act of theft; the tithe belongs to God, not us. In what way are we stealing from God? Can you think of ways that refusing to tithe rob us? What does God promise in return for tithing faithfully? (Mal. 3:8-12) ❧

Shawn Boonstra is an associate editor at Adventist Review.



TWO ANGELS IN A BOAT

A rescue that left no footprints

Dick Duerksen



The afternoon air was hot, a Mozambique heat that brings bubbles of sweat to your forehead even when you're not moving. My friend Simoque and I were resting on a stack of bricks in the shade of an ancient cashew tree. We were supposed to be working and had, in fact, spent the past half hour moving freshly made bricks into stacks where they could dry quickly.

I should tell you a bit more about our situation. Simoque and I were attempting to help a group of volunteers build a new primary school in Liberdade, a suburb of Maputo, the capital city of Mozambique. The volunteers were pushing wheelbarrows filled with thick red dirt toward the wheezing brickmaking machine. Several local workers operated the machine, pouring dirt in one end and extracting cubes of well-pressed bricks from the other.

Everything—including the machine, the palm-thatch kitchen hut, a nearby tractor, and all the humans—was covered in thick red dust. Well, that's not quite accurate. It may have begun as dust,

but as humidity mixed with sweat, the dust transformed into a murky burgundy slime that matted our hair and dripped from the tips of our noses.

The volunteers had come from America, Australia, South Africa, and the Netherlands. Most knew far more about building than Simoque and I could ever hope to learn. We were pastors, two nonagile fellows whose life experiences did not include brickmaking.

"Simoque," I asked my friend, "does it ever rain in Mozambique?"

He was quiet for such a long time that I cracked my eyes open to see if he had fallen asleep. He noticed, smiled an Africa-wide smile, and said, "Pastor Dick, may I tell you a story?"

I adjusted my seat on the bricks and leaned toward my friend.

"I'm ready."



Twenty-two Churches and One Pastor

“Once upon a time . . . actually, it was about 12 years ago,” Simoque began, “I was a young pastor living with my wife and children up-country in the seaside town of Xai-Xai. We chose to live on the edge of the Limpopo River because it was near the railroad station and near a road where I could quickly jump on a bus and travel to any of my many churches.

“I was responsible for 22 congregations, if I remember correctly.”

“Twenty-two?” I questioned.

“Yep,” he said, smiling. “The elders from all those congregations joined me one afternoon each week beneath a giant cashew tree—like the one we’re under today. I’d give them the week’s sermon, discuss the text, and then help them think through the biggest challenges they were facing in their congregations.”

“What did you do on Sabbath?” I asked.

“I’d go to two or more churches every Sabbath. Usually my wife and two sons would join me for what was always a very long and tiring Sabbath day. We didn’t own a car, so we traveled by minibus or train. Church members led the evangelism and Bible studies, and I came whenever I could to preach a sermon and baptize new believers.”

“I’ve never imagined serving as pastor for that many congregations,” I groaned. “With so many churches to care for, I imagine that you were away from home most of the time, traveling wherever you were needed and helping everyone stay on the right path.”

Simoque ignored my interruption and continued with his story.

When the water reached my waist, I knew I would probably not make it across the Limpopo. I shouted out to God for protection—not for me, but for my family.

Underwater Prayers

“One day I was away on a journey when a giant typhoon blew across the ocean from Madagascar and landed on Mozambique. The rain fell in buckets, turning dry ground across Mozambique, Zimbabwe, and Malawi into lakes of water.

“Knowing that the rain and wind would terrify my wife and children, I immediately started for home, praying loudly for the good Lord to protect my family and guide me to their side.

“Travel was very difficult. The streets were flooded, and no minivans or taxis were operating. The rain was so heavy that even the trains had stopped running. I was on my own, with only one way to get to my family: I would have to walk the many kilometers home.

“I chose to walk on the railroad tracks, hoping they would be above the rushing flood. With every step I reached out in prayer, hoping to grasp my guardian angel’s steady hand.

“Late in the night I finally came to the wide Limpopo River, where a new sound roared in my ears. Muddy typhoon water had risen high and was rushing across the Limpopo railroad bridge, threatening to wash away my only way of escape.

“I could see partway across the river and knew I would have to hurry if I was going to reach the other side before the bridge tore away and made it impossible for me to get home.

“I moved slowly along the railroad rails on the bridge, ice-cold water tearing at my feet—water that quickly rose to cover my ankles and then my knees. I slogged on, placing each foot carefully on one

of the wooden ties that ran between the iron tracks. With one hand I still clutched tightly to my angel's imaginary hand. Every breath was a prayer.

"When the water reached my waist, I knew I would probably not make it across the Limpopo. I shouted out to God for protection—not for me, but for my family.

"I knew I had to keep going, had to get home to my wife, must be with my boys. As I took one more dangerous step, the railroad bridge shuddered beneath me. I slipped, and the water ran clear up to my neck. In big trouble, I shouted a prayer as loud as I could!

"That's when I fell into a very deep hole. My head went under the water, and I knew I would never see my family again—not until heaven."

Simoque stopped speaking, and suddenly the air felt hotter, more clammy, redder, and dirtier than before.

The brickmaking machine clanged far off in the distance. I had stopped breathing, as if drowning in muddy water with my friend.

"Pastor Dick, God answers even underwater prayers."

Simoque's voice—and the truth that he was right here, sitting beside me and telling me his story—pulled me back to reality.

**Instead of a floating log,
I saw the impossible.
Paddling hard beside
me were two men in
a small fishing boat!**

His eyes were closed and his hands clenched, as if reliving the moment he was drowning in the river.

"Deep down under the water," he continued, "I shouted for God to come to me, to help me, to save me!

"Suddenly I bobbed to the top of the river like a stray plastic bottle."

Strangers in a Boat

Simoque stopped speaking, looked over at me, took a deep breath, and smiled.

"I breathed all the air I could and looked around for something to grab on to, something that might give me a chance to live. Instead of a floating log, I saw the impossible. Paddling hard beside me were two men in a small fishing boat!

"They saw me, caught me, pulled me in, and handed me a dry blanket.

"Where are you going?" one of the men asked.

"I coughed up a lot of water while I told them about my family and why I needed to get home. Then I asked what they were doing out there in the flood.

"We're fishing," one of them laughed.

"In this flood?" I responded, amazed that anyone would be out in weather like this.

"Oh, yes. This is a very good time to fish. We caught you, didn't we?"

"The men carried me for many hours until we saw a light shining in my house up the hill above the river. They seemed to know right where to go and drove the boat deep into the mud below my house.

"Thank you, thank you, thank you!" I cried. "Please let me go inside and get my money to pay you."

"The fishermen argued with me, saying they didn't need to be paid. But finally they agreed to wait for me while I went to get them some money.

"I splashed up to the house, every step sending a bucket of ugly mud toward the sky. My family was so happy to see me, but I hugged each one quickly, ran to my room to get the money, ran back out the door, and sloshed through the mud down to the boat."

Simoque's storytelling went silent.

"Pastor Dick, there was no boat.

"There were not even any marks in the mud where they had driven the boat aground so I could jump off. There was nothing! No trace. No sign that they had ever even been there."

Simoque looked through my eyes and deep into my heart. Then he cleared his throat and spoke again, almost silently, as if in the quiet of a cathedral.

"Pastor Dick, there was no boat. No fishermen. Just two angels—out fishing for Simoque!" ❧

Dick Duerksen is a pastor and storyteller living in Portland, Oregon, United States.



THE REVERSE PATH OF HOPE

The same Lord who rebukes still knocks.

Revelation 2 and 3 do more than address ancient congregations. They function as an apocalyptic diagnosis of God's people living at the edge of history.

Among the seven churches, Laodicea and Philadelphia stand in deliberate contrast. One exposes the danger of spiritual complacency; the other reveals the power of faithful endurance. Between them lies the reverse path of hope.

Laodicea was prosperous, influential, and confident. Archaeology confirms its banking system, medical facilities, and textile industry. Yet its hidden weakness matched its water supply: lukewarm by the time it arrived through long aqueducts. The Bible speaks with

precision: "So then, because you are lukewarm, and neither cold nor hot, I will vomit you out of My mouth" (Rev. 3:16). In other words, complacency numbs faith.

At Laodicea's core lies a theological distortion: "Because you say, 'I am rich, have become wealthy, and have need of nothing'" (Rev. 3:17). We have a dangerous situation here: religion continues, yet dependence fades; doctrine remains, yet trembling is gone; mission survives, yet urgency evaporates. Christ is not denied but displaced. The verdict exposes the tragedy: "... and do not know that you are wretched, miserable, poor, blind, and naked" (verse 17). Yet the message also contains an appeal: "As many as I love, I rebuke and chasten. Therefore, be zealous and repent" (verse 19). That is, the same Lord who rebukes still knocks. He offers restored fellowship.

On the other hand, Philadelphia presents a striking reversal. Historically weak, frequently shaken by earthquakes, it was a city accustomed to instability. Yet Christ

offers no rebuke. "You have a little strength, have kept My word, and have not denied My name" (verse 8). Fidelity, not appearance, defines the faithful. Endurance, not comfort, marks the people of God. "Because you have kept My command to persevere" (verse 10).

For Seventh-day Adventists this contrast determines our prophetic identity. The church recognizes itself living in the Laodicean era, yet is called to reflect the spirit of Philadelphia. The measuring standard is found in Revelation 14. The three angels' messages restore urgency, re-center worship, and clarify allegiance. "Fear

Fidelity, not appearance, defines the faithful. Endurance, not comfort, marks the people of God.

God and give glory to Him . . . ; and worship Him who made heaven and earth" (Rev. 14:7). This is not optional theology; it is end-time proclamation.

The reverse path of hope moves from comfort to conviction. From institutional confidence to covenant loyalty. From complacent religion to urgent fidelity. Scripture warns that truth has never advanced by majority. "Many are called, but few are chosen" (Matt. 22:14). The final witness will be carried by a faithful remnant, anchored in Scripture and awakened by prophecy.

Here is the call of this hour. Leave the theology of complacency. Embrace the fidelity of urgency. Let doctrine ignite devotion. Let devotion fuel mission. The world does not need a church impressed with itself; it needs a people filled with Christ, grounded in the Bible, and focused on the mission. Courageous enough to proclaim the everlasting gospel until the door that is still open finally closes.

From Laodicea to Philadelphia, the Spirit still speaks. Will you answer? **✝**

Erton C. Köhler is the president of the General Conference of Seventh-day Adventists.



**ADVENTIST
REVIEW**

Vol. 203, No. 5

Founded 1849. Published by the General Conference of Seventh-day Adventists, Northern Asia-Pacific Division

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The *Adventist Review* (ISSN 0161-1119) is the general paper of the Seventh-day Adventist® Church. It is printed simultaneously around the world in Argentina, Australia, Austria, Brazil, Germany, Indonesia, Korea, Mexico, South Africa, and the United States. It is published monthly by the General Conference of Seventh-day Adventists®, 12501 Old Columbia Pike, Silver Spring, MD 20904, U.S.A. The Korean editorial and business offices are located at the Northern Asia-Pacific Division, 67-20 Beonttwigi-gil, Paju-si, Gyeonggi-do 10909, Republic of Korea.

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